GROWTH BLUEPRINT ADVISORY

Real Estate

The Saudi market-entry brief

THE SECTOR IN PLAIN WORDS

Before we start

Property in Saudi Arabia is being shaped by scale: large programmes, new districts and a rising need for homes, offices, retail and hospitality space. That creates room for new developers, investors and operators. It also means the market moves on a timetable set by projects far larger than any single company.

This brief helps you understand how the sector is organised, which parts of regulation to confirm first, and how to build a sensible first step instead of an expensive leap. It assumes you are an investor, developer or operator who is new to the Kingdom or growing your presence.

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Please note. This brief is general guidance written by advisers. It is not legal, tax or investment advice. Rules and programmes change, so confirm current requirements with the relevant authority and licensed advisers before you act. We do not include market-size statistics because they date quickly; ask us for current figures.

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02

What is driving demand

Population and household growth

More households need homes, and more businesses need space, which supports demand across residential, commercial and mixed-use.

Large-scale programmes

New districts and destination projects create demand for developers, designers, contractors, operators and suppliers.

Regulatory modernisation

Rules on registration, rental platforms and off-plan sales have been evolving to bring more clarity and protection to buyers and investors.

Investor interest in income-producing assets

Offices, logistics, retail and hospitality assets attract capital looking for stable returns.

03

How the market is organised

The market at a glance.

Who is active	Government-linked master developers, large private developers, contractors, consultants, brokers and increasingly institutional investors.
Where the activity is	Major cities, new planned districts and destination projects, each with its own authority and process.
How deals happen	Through partnerships, joint ventures, land arrangements and tenders, often with long lead times.
What decides success	Land access, approvals, delivery partners, financing and the pace of local demand.
Typical first move	A partnership or joint venture on a defined project, rather than a large standalone programme.

04

Ways in

Joint venture with a local developer

You bring capital, design or operating expertise; they bring land, relationships and approvals. Terms and governance matter enormously.

Project-by-project partnership

Enter one defined project with a clear scope. Easier to exit, and a good way to learn.

Investing in existing assets or funds

Lower development risk, but you rely on the quality of your manager and asset.

Service entry

Offer design, project management, facilities or advisory services to existing developers.

05

Rules to check early

Confirm these early, with the relevant authority and a licensed adviser.

- [ ] Foreign ownership and investment rules for the asset type and location you have in mind, which have been evolving. Confirm the current position.
- [ ] Licensing and registration requirements for developers, brokers and project managers.
- [ ] Rules on off-plan sales, escrow arrangements and buyer protection for residential projects.
- [ ] Planning, zoning and building approvals, which can differ by city and district.
- [ ] Tax treatment, including VAT and real-estate transaction taxes, with a licensed tax adviser.

06

Partners: who you will meet

Master developers and land owners

They control land and timing. Understand their pipeline and how they choose partners.

Contractors and consultants

Capacity is a real constraint on large programmes. Check availability and track record.

Brokers and local advisers

Useful for introductions and market colour. Be clear on how they are paid.

Financiers and funds

Early conversations on financing shape what you can afford to build.

07

Where people go wrong

Underestimating approval time

Timelines slip when approvals depend on each other.

Weak partner terms

Vague governance and exit terms cause trouble when the first disagreement arrives.

Assuming demand is uniform

Neighbourhoods, price points and asset types behave very differently.

Ignoring contractor capacity

A good design with no one to build it on time is not a project.

Treating rules as fixed

Regulation has been changing, so check what applies today.

08

Your first 90 days

Days 1 to 30: orient

- List the districts, asset types and partners that fit your strategy.
- Confirm current foreign-investment rules for your target asset.
- Speak to three people who have developed or invested here.

Days 31 to 60: shortlist

- Compare two or three project or partner options on the same criteria.
- Build a rough development and cash-flow model with realistic timelines.
- Take legal and tax advice on structure.

Days 61 to 90: structure

- Negotiate term sheets with clear governance and exit routes.
- Agree a phased commitment that lets you pause.
- Set up the entity and licences you actually need.

09

Questions to ask before you commit

Take these into your next meeting. If you cannot answer one, that is your next piece of homework.

- [ ] What exactly do we bring that a local developer does not already have?
- [ ] Which approvals does this project depend on, and in what order?
- [ ] Who decides what in the partnership, and what happens if we disagree?
- [ ] How do we exit, and on what terms?
- [ ] What is our plan if approvals take 30 percent longer than expected?
- [ ] Who are the contractors, and do they have capacity for our timeline?
- [ ] What is the demand evidence for this district and price point?
- [ ] What do we need to be true for this to work, and how will we test it?

ملخص بالعربية

العقارات: موجز دخول السوق السعودي

يوضح هذا الموجز كيف يتنظم القطاع العقاري في السعودية ومن اللاعبون الرئيسيون فيه، وكيف تُبرم الصفقات عادةً عبر الشراكات والمشاريع المشتركة والمناقصات. ستجد فيه الأنظمة التي ينبغي التحقق منها مبكرًا مثل التملك الأجنبي والترخيص والبيع على الخارطة والموافقات التخطيطية، ومنهجًا لاختيار الشريك، وأخطاء شائعة، وخطة لأول ٩٠ يومًا. وخلاصتنا: ابدأ بمشروع محدد وشريك واضح الشروط، وراجع الأنظمة الحالية مع مستشارين مرخّصين، وخطط لتأخر الموافقات.

هذا الموجز إرشاد عام كتبه مستشارون، وليس مشورة قانونية أو ضريبية أو استثمارية. تتغير الأنظمة والبرامج، فتأكد دائمًا من المتطلبات الحالية مع الجهة المختصة ومستشارين مرخّصين.